Reflection: User Stories and Tasks

What we did

As a team, we used our Trello board to plan the NavigSA project through user stories and tasks. We built a Product Backlog of 28 stories and then broke them down into 52 daily sprint cards across Sprint Week 1 to Sprint Week 13. Every card has a user story at the top and a short description of the work underneath.

We wrote stories for five different kinds of user: the international student, the French- or Portuguese-speaking student, the service provider, the administrator and our project supervisor. We also marked each backlog story as High or Medium priority so that everyone knew what to build first.

What went well

Most of our stories are written from the student's point of view and say clearly why the feature matters. For example: *"As an international student, I want to track my application progress so that I always know what stage my application is in."* The "so that" part kept us thinking about the student instead of only the technology.

Splitting big stories into daily cards worked well for us. The student dashboard was too large for one day, so we split it across Sprint 33 (build and integrate the dashboard), Sprint 34 (bookings, appointments and notifications) and Sprint 35 (connect it to the backend and test). We did the same with multilingual content: Sprint 46 completed the translations and Sprint 47 checked that they were accurate. This made our progress easy to see on the board.

We even wrote our testing work as user stories, such as Sprint 41: *"I want NavigSA to be tested by real users so that the platform is easy to use and reliable."* This reminded us that testing is about the student's experience, not just finding bugs.

What we struggled with

Looking back over the board, we can see several things we would do differently:

- **No tasks or acceptance criteria on the cards.** The work for each story only lived in the card title and the short description. None of our cards had a checklist, so it was not always clear when a card was really finished.
- **One story was too big.** Sprints 29 to 32 all use the same story ("I want my information to be stored securely..."). The work was actually four technical steps: backend setup, database design, database models and APIs. We should have written it as one story with four tasks.
- **Titles that didn't match the story.** Some cards were copied and the story was changed, but not the title. Sprint 15 is called "Complete the financial planning" but its story is about the brand guide, and Sprint 11 is called "Collect customer feedback" but its story is about provider onboarding.

- **Stories that are not really user stories.** Some cards, such as the monthly reports, were written as "As a project supervisor, I want...". That work was important, but it is a project task rather than a feature for a user, and forcing it into the story template made it less clear.
- **The backlog was not kept up to date.** 21 of the 28 backlog stories are still not ticked complete, even where the sprint work is done. Secure Login, for example, was built in Sprint 25. Three stories (Manage Student Profile, Administrator Manages Users and Build Strategic Partnerships) were never planned into a sprint at all.

What we learnt

We learnt that a user story is only the starting point. To be useful to the team, it also needs clear acceptance criteria that say when it is done, a size that fits in one sprint, and a list of tasks. We also learnt that the Trello board is only good evidence if it is kept accurate. When the titles, statuses and stories don't match, the board stops telling the true story of the project.

Going back through every card to refine the stories showed us how much clearer the project would have been if we had added the acceptance criteria and tasks from the start.

What we will do differently next time

- Write two or three acceptance criteria for every story before it goes into a sprint.
- Add the tasks to each card as a Trello checklist, so that we can tick them off and progress is visible.
- Split stories that are too big into smaller stories, instead of repeating the same story across several days.
- Keep project admin, such as reports and presentations, as tasks rather than user stories.
- At the end of each sprint week, tick off the finished backlog stories and check that every card's title matches its story.